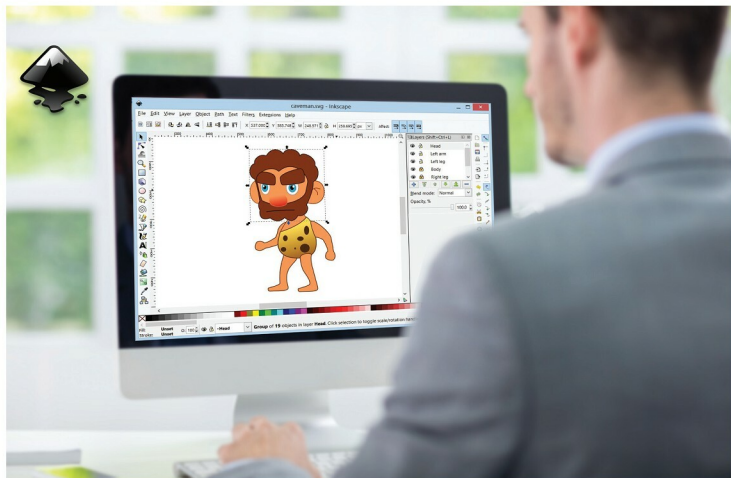


Caricaturing with Inkscape

Inkscape is a great open source tool for drawing cartoons. In this article, you can learn how to use it to create simple caricatures.



GIMP and Inkscape are the two main open source software available for graphics artists. Very generally speaking, GIMP is for photos and Inkscape is for drawings. Since drawings are vector images, Inkscape is the better option for such graphics. Inkscape is also a better option if you do not have a drawing tablet-stylus device such as those from Wacom. This is because vector drawing tools such as Inkscape rely on a combination of shapes rather than raw raster content and brush strokes to create images.

Many open source artists work only with GIMP, being unaware of Inkscape. I had tried Inkscape in the past and concluded that it was powerful but difficult. I created some custom desktop icons like the one shown in Figure 1 and forgot about it.

Lately, I have been watching some cartoons and this made me get back to working on Inkscape. I now have a small 'clip art' library with images like what's shown in Figure 2. (I believe this image depicts a more anatomically accurate shark than Sharko!)



Figure 1: A custom desktop icon created using Inkscape



Figure 2: An anatomically accurate shark caricature created using Inkscape

But the task was still pretty laborious. Later, when reading a book on Dilbert cartoons, I realised that it need not be so difficult. If you observe carefully, Dilbert cartoons are extremely simple. The caricatures are a combination of simple lines twisted here and there, minimal shading and that is about it. If you were to follow Scott Adam's (Dilbert's creator) production technique, then your Inkscape work would be much easier. What this means is that you can start drawing cartoons and caricatures with just your mouse!

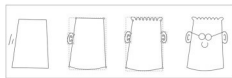


Figure 3: Dilbert caricatures are a combination of simple lines